

49. Gender quotas

ANA CATALANO WEEKS

Women remain underrepresented in most parliaments worldwide. As a remedy, many political parties and countries have turned to gender quotas. Gender quotas are provisions that require women's presence among candidates or political representatives. In politics, three main types of gender quotas exist: 1) party quotas, 2) electoral quotas, and 3) political reservations (reserved seats). Party quotas are voluntary provisions political parties make to boost the selection of women candidates, often included in party statutes (see entry on Gendered party organizational Structures by Miki Caul Kittilson and Netty Herawaty). Electoral quotas (also called quota laws) mandate *all* political parties to include a certain share of women among their candidate slates. Political reservations are policies that reserve a certain share of places in the legislature for women, requiring women to be elected rather than only nominated.

Quotas are widely used by political parties and governments across the globe, and regional patterns can be observed in their use. While most countries in Europe employ party quotas, nearly every single country in Latin America now has a gender quota law. Political reservations are more often found in Africa (see entry on African feminisms by Tomi Adeaga) and the Middle East. As of 2022, nearly 90 countries had legal quotas or reservations for women, and many more have formal or informal party rules (author's dataset, extending Hughes, Paxton, Clayton, and Zetterberg 2015). The remarkable spread of quota provisions in recent decades represents perhaps the most significant electoral reform our times have witnessed. Not surprisingly, the study of gender quotas is a well-established subfield among scholars of gender and politics. In this entry, I give a short summary of the major findings related to the causes and consequences of gender quotas, before critically appraising limitations and gaps in knowledge and pointing to some fruitful directions for future research.

Causes of gender quotas

As quotas spread rapidly across the globe, scholars sought to understand the main drivers of change. Existing literature points to several important explanations, and I highlight

six of these here. First, *electoral institutions* matter. Quotas are more likely to be adopted in proportional representation (PR) systems with multi-member districts, where parties present lists of multiple candidates, than in single-member districts, where they are perceived as more difficult to implement (although notable exceptions exist, such as France). While women can be added to lists of candidates in PR systems without endangering the places of many male incumbents, quotas in single-member districts require replacing a man with a woman. Second, *women activists* have mobilized successfully for quota reforms, both within political parties where women legislators have often worked together across party lines to push reforms through, and within women's social movements which campaigned successfully for change in several countries (see entry on Women's pathways to power by Francesca Feo and Ragnhild Louise Muriaas; see entry on Feminist political thought by Elena Icardi and Francesca Cesarano). For example, in her study of quota adoption in Mexico, Baldez (2004) highlights the critical importance of the united front of the women Members of Parliament (MPs) which drummed up public support and made it very difficult for male colleagues to oppose the quota. Third, *policy diffusion* played a key role in many cases, where transnational sharing about quotas paved the way for reforms. In her analysis of quota adoption and implementation in six countries, Krook (2010) finds that nearly all of the reforms analyzed included significant influence from international organizations or networks, such as the United Nations, Council of Europe, and the Socialist International, where women often shared ideas across borders. Fourth, quotas in one sphere of political life can beget more quotas as they become normalized in a "*mutual contagion effect*", as Meier (2004) describes in the evolution from party quotas to legal quotas in Belgium. Fifth, *party competition* – both between parties and within parties – can open windows of opportunity for change as struggling parties compete for women voters and seek to maintain control over candidate selection (Weeks 2018) (see entry on Party membership and affiliation by Karina Kosiara-Pedersen). Last but not least, the same kind of strategic incentives to adopt a quota can also be observed within autocracies (see entry on Gender, autocracy, and democracy in postcommunist states by

Katalin Fábián), which use gender quotas to shore up their international reputations and attract foreign aid (Bush and Zetterberg 2021).

Consequences of gender quotas

What difference do gender quotas make? A large body of research explores the question of whether gender quotas are effective at achieving their primary aim of increasing women's descriptive representation (number of women in office). Overwhelmingly, the answer is yes: quotas work. The scholarly consensus is that, by and large, quotas are an effective "fast track" solution at boosting numbers of women in office (Dahlerup and Freidenvall 2005). Tripp and Kang's (2008) study of women's legislative representation worldwide shows that gender quotas have even greater impacts on levels of women's representation than other institutional factors – making them among the very best predictors of women's representation. Of course, the provisions of the quota – the share of women required, rules about placement on lists, and consequences for not complying – condition the effects of quota laws. Quota laws that require higher thresholds of women, placement mandates specifying that women must hold certain positions on the ballot, and strict enforcement mechanisms for compliance are more effective (Schwindt-Bayer 2009).

Even though gender quotas work and are very popular, they are still controversial. One of the main challenges that comes up in debates about gender quotas is that candidates should be elected for their quality – on their own merit – not because of their gender. The implicit argument here – which is also often made explicitly – is that gender quotas will reduce the quality of those in elected office. Here, evidence from reams of studies of quotas across countries (too many to cite here) is clear: gender quotas do not lead to less qualified politicians in office. In fact, research also finds the opposite effect: gender quotas improve the quality of legislators. This is because fewer low-quality or "mediocre" male politicians make it into office (Besley et al. 2017).

Increasingly, scholars are beginning to study the effects of quotas on other important political outcomes, beyond descriptive representation and the qualifications of politicians. These include effects on the diversity of legislators elected, women's empowerment

in leadership roles, like mayor or party leader, political parties' policy priorities, and policy outcomes. Because this line of research is relatively new – scholars are still refining theory and testing new cases – the evidence is more mixed. For example, while some studies suggest that gender quotas can pave the way for women's access to positions of power (O'Brien and Rickne 2016), others report little evidence that gender quotas "filter up" or have impacts beyond the intended offices (Spaziani 2022). The evidence about gender quotas' influence on diversity is also mixed. In a study of Argentina, Barnes and Holman (2020) show that quotas increase the professional and class diversity of legislators, but the extent to which they also affect other dimensions of diversity, such as race/ethnicity, remains unclear. As I discuss below, these questions provide a valuable avenue for future research.

Policy impacts

In debates about gender quotas around the world, advocates often argue that quotas will have an impact on a set of loosely defined "women's issues". The question of whether gender quotas produce meaningful policy change for women is critical for understanding whether quotas can enhance not only the descriptive but also the substantive representation of women. Scholars have investigated this question in a range of different countries and institutional contexts. Overall, the results suggest that gender quotas, and the associated increase in women's descriptive representation they bring, can lead to significant policy changes. Globally, studies show that quotas are associated with more state spending on public health and welfare (e.g., Clayton and Zetterberg 2018) (see entry on Care, reproductive labour, and politics by Elena Zacharenko). Investment in such areas is consistent with women's structural inequalities, which leave them exposed to greater risk in labor and marriage markets, and with gendered socialization patterns which emphasize communality and social harmony as feminine values.

One important question that scholars face when studying policy impacts of quotas within regions and countries is which policies to focus on. Given that women's political preferences are varied and differ across social and political contexts, it follows that

the effects of quotas should not always be the same everywhere. Using public opinion data can help because it provides a measure of women's political preferences and evidence about gender gaps in preferences. For example, in India political reservations for women at the local level increased investment in water and roads, issues that tend to be more prioritized by women than men in this context (Chattopadhyay and Duflo 2004). Meanwhile in the context of high-income, OECD democracies, gender quota laws lead to work-family policies that are better aligned with women's shared preferences for combining work and family, such as more weeks of paid shared parental and paternity leave (Weeks 2022).

How, exactly, do quotas lead to policy change? Gender quotas rarely apply to leadership positions with direct policy influence, such as mayor or party leader. However, by increasing women's political presence and raising the topic in visible ways, quotas can increase the chances that women ascend to these leadership roles (see entry on Women and leadership in the executive by Henriette Müller) down the line, their bargaining power as a group, and the salience of gender equality in politics broadly speaking. This does not mean that quotas are a panacea. In those cases where gender quotas do not expand women's access to power, due to e.g., institutional barriers and masculinist culture, studies have shown that quotas might lead to more attention given to women's interests in debates and bills proposed, but not substantive policy gains (Franceschet and Piscopo 2008). This means that quota designs are a start, but achieving policy change likely requires male elites to relinquish power.

Strengths, limitations, and future research directions

The study of gender quotas is now a developed subfield benefiting from several decades of research. Strengths of this subfield include rich theory and robust empirical evidence on the various determinants of quota adoption, the process of implementation (and, often, strategies of party avoidance), and the impacts of quotas on the descriptive representation of women. Case studies effectively illustrate causal mechanisms at work in different contexts, including countries from a variety of regions, including Latin America, Europe, Africa, and Asia, especially India's

randomly allocated political reservations for women. However, the first limitation I note is that certain knowledge gaps remain related to the geographic coverage of our evidence base – for example, the implementation of gender quotas in Eastern Europe, the Balkans, and the Middle East (but see Belschner 2022).

Another strength of existing studies is their methodological diversity. Gender quotas have been studied from a range of quantitative and qualitative methodological approaches, utilizing interviews, longitudinal datasets such as Quota Adoption and Reform Over Time (QAROT) (Hughes et al. 2017), observational and experimental survey data, and quasi-experimental approaches. Of course, some limitations remain due to data availability and case selection. While some parties and countries have had quotas in place for many decades, just as many have implemented quotas relatively recently. This necessarily limits what we know about long-term impacts. A second limitation is thus related to understanding the impacts of quotas over time, as well as the scope conditions and generalizability of case-based findings. Additional comparative and longitudinal studies would help build generalizable evidence about the influence of gender quotas over time and on other important outcomes of interest, beyond numbers of women in office. For example, we do not yet know whether quotas increase the share of women in cabinets, or boost the appointment of women as party leaders, worldwide. Future research is needed to investigate whether (and under which conditions) quotas can facilitate access to the highest positions of power.

Third, more research is needed on the effects of quotas on public opinion and political participation across countries – and here research should investigate the potential for both empowerment and backlash. The question of whether gender quotas increase political engagement and ambition among women citizens, and reduce negative stereotypes about women in politics, is challenging because we often lack access to the kind of data that allows us to examine opinion before and after a quota – the timing of surveys is not right, or the right questions have not been asked. We should expand observational and experimental data collection so that we can better understand how patterns in political engagement shift when women are more visible in politics, as Hinojosa and Kittilson (2020) do in the case of Uruguay. Future

research can develop this agenda by investigating the extent to which gender quotas lead to backlash against women politicians. This question is all the more relevant as we witness democratic backsliding on women's rights and anti-gender movements in many countries (see entry on Anti-Gender campaigns by David Paternotte; see entry on The manosphere and anti-gender backlash on social media by Malin Holm). While gender quotas might empower some women citizens, they could equally anger other (especially men) citizens, who might mobilize efforts against such measures. For example, Kim and Kweon (2022) find that young men in particular are threatened by gender quotas in South Korea, leading to a substantial gender gap in public opinion on the issue. It is important for future research to investigate whether gender quotas might increase the potential for violence against women in politics (see entry on Gendered violence against politicians by Sandra Hakansson).

A fourth limitation and the final one I will mention here is related to gendered identities and intersectionality (see entry on Approaches to measurement and analysis of intersectionality in survey research by Vera Beloshitzkaya et al.; see entry on Politics of intersectionality and the study of violence by Nadia E. Brown et al.). There is now a growing understanding of gender beyond the binary of man/woman – including nonbinary people and the spectrum of masculinities and femininities that make up gendered identities – in the scholarly community, by governments, and among the public. This poses some challenges related to who is counted under a gender quota, and what gender balance in parliaments means more broadly. The recent case of withdrawn quota plans in Wales suggests that these issues can be used by anti-gender movements to drum up opposition against gender quotas due to the (in this case, inclusive) way the law defines gender (Shipton 2023). In addition, the majority of existing studies investigate the impacts of quotas on women as a homogeneous group, when in reality class, race, and other dimensions also shape lived experiences in intersectional ways. It is unclear who exactly benefits – which women? – from gender quotas, and how the effects of quotas on representation and power might be conditioned by race, class, and other characteristics. Future studies should continue to make progress on this by investigating how quotas relate not only to

the election of men and women but also the intersectional and gendered identities of candidates and politicians.

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